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Léa

February 1943

As the days barreled on, relentless snow one day, biting cold the next, the sisters toiled long hours on the factory floor. The dull winter sun shone through the factory window as Léa dipped a fine brush into the balsam and painted a thin line along the edge of the glass lens. With steady hands, she pressed the lens into the metal mount, ensuring it was centered. Her fingers, stiff and aching, and her neck sore, she took care not to touch the optical surface as any smudge would degrade the lens quality. Finished, she set the assembled piece on a rack for the warm oven.

The light bulbs overhead flickered. They'd experienced a blackout earlier in the day, but the Meister shouted at the workers to keep going. Léa, struggling to see, hesitated with the balsam, worried she might dab some on the lens. She picked up the next unfinished part from the assembly line, then glanced sideways at the woman sitting beside her. Her name was Maria, and she wore a purple P badge sewn on the front of her apron, marking her as Polish.

Unlike many of the women who bantered in German while working—Léa's German wasn't yet good enough to join in the conversation—Maria never spoke. Léa had the impression she wanted to be as small as possible, as if trying to become invisible. The Meister's frequent slurs directed at her —*filthy Polish pig*—made Léa's stomach churn with anger. Wanting to comfort her or at least show kindness, Léa would try to meet Maria's gaze, but she always lowered her eyes or turned away.

Today, Maria's right eye was swollen and red. As she worked, she paused, looked up at the ceiling and closed her eyes for relief. If the Meister